Pearl of Great Price
Fact Sheet

FIRST EDITION

1. WHEN: 15 June 1851.
2. WHO: Elder Franklin D. Richards, President of the British Mission and newest member of the Council of the Twelve Apostles.
3. WHY: The saints in the British Isles did not have access to Mormon literature.
4. WHERE: Published at Liverpool.
5. WHAT: See the PREFACE [*removed from subsequent editions*]:

"The following compilation has been induced by the repeated solicitations of several friends of the publisher, who are desirous to be put in possession of the very important articles contained therein. Most of the revelations composing this work were published at early periods of the Church, when the circulation of its journals was so very limited as to render them comparatively unknown at present, except to a few who have treasured up the productions of the Church with great care from the beginning. A smaller portion of this work has never before appeared in print; and altogether it is presumed, that true believers in the Divine mission of the Prophet Joseph Smith, will appreciate this little collection of precious truths as a *Pearl of Great Price* that will increase their ability to maintain and to defend the holy faith by becoming possessors of it.

"Although not adopted, not designed, as a pioneer of the faith among unbelievers, still it will commend itself to all careful students of the scriptures, as detailing many important facts which are therein only alluded to, or entirely unmentioned, but consonant with the whole tenor of the revealed will of God; and, to the beginner in the Gospel, will add confirmatory evidence of the rectitude of his faith, by showing him that the doctrines and ordinances thereof are the same as were revealed to Adam for his salvation after his expulsion from the garden, and the same that he handed down and caused to be taught to his generations after him, as the only means appointed of God by which the generations of men may regain His presence.

"Nor do we conceive it possible for any unprejudiced person to arise from a careful perusal of this work, without being deeply impressed with a sense of the divine calling, and holy ordination, of the man by whom these revelations, translations, and narrations have been communicated to us. As impervious as the minds of men may be at present to these convictions, the day is not far distant when sinners, as well as Saints, will know that JOSEPH SMITH was one of the greatest men that ever lived upon the earth, and that under God he was the Prophet and founder of the dispensation of the fulness of times, in which will be gathered together in one all things which are in Christ, both which are in heaven and which are on earth."

TABLE OF CONTENTS OF 1ST EDITION [pages vii-viii]:

Page 1—"Extracts from the Prophecy of Enoch, containing also a Revelation of the Gospel unto our father Adam, after he was driven out from the Garden of Eden. Revealed to Joseph Smith, December, 1830 [See Moses 6:43-7:69.]

Page 8—"The words of God, which he spake unto Moses at the time when Moses was caught up into an exceeding high mountain, and he saw God face to face, and he talked with him, and the glory of God was upon Moses; therefore Moses could endure His presence. Revealed to Joseph Smith, June, 1830 [See Moses 1:1—4:19, 22-25; 5:1-16*a*, 19-23, 32-40; Moses 8:13-30.]

Page 19—"THE BOOK OF ABRAHAM.—A Translation of some Ancient Records, that have fallen into our hands from the Catacombs of Egypt, purporting to be the writings of Abraham while he was in Egypt, called the Book of Abraham, written by his own hand upon Papyrus. Translated from the Papyrus by Joseph Smith [See Abraham 1-5.]

Page 30—"An Extract from a Translation of the Bible—being the twenty-fourth chapter of Matthew, commencing with the last verse of the twenty-third chapter. By the Prophet, Seer, and Revelator, Joseph Smith [See Joseph Smith–Matthew.]
Page 33—"A Key to the Revelations of St. John. By Joseph Smith [See D&C 77.]
Page 35—"A Revelation and Prophecy by the Prophet, Seer, and Revelator, Joseph Smith. Given December 25th, 1832 [See D&C 87.]
Page 36—"EXTRACTS FROM THE HISTORY OF JOSEPH SMITH,—Containing an Account of the first Visions and Revelations which he received; also of his discovering and obtaining the plates of gold which contain the Record of Mormon—its translation—his baptism, and ordination by the Angel;—Items of Doctrine from the Revelations and Commandments of the Church [See Joseph Smith–History.]
Page 48—"FROM THE DOCTRINE AND COVENANTS OF THE CHURCH— Commandment to the Church Concerning Baptism [See D&C 20:71, 37, 72-74.]
Page 49—"The Duties of the Members after they are received by Baptism [See D&C 20:68-69.]
Page 50—"On Priesthood [See D&C 107:1-10, 12-20.]
Page 51—"The Calling and Duties of the Twelve Apostles [See D&C 107:23, 33.]
Page 52—"The Calling and Duties of the Seventy [See D&C 107:34-35, 93-100.]
Page 52—"Extract from a Revelation given July, 1830 [See D&C 27:5-18.]
Page 53—"Rise of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints [See D&C 20:1-36.]
Page 55—"'Times and Seasons,' vol. III, page 709 [See Articles of Faith.]
Page 56—"Truth ('Oh Say, What Is Truth?' *Hymns,* 1985, no. 272; lyrics by John Jaques]

"INDEX TO WOODCUTS.

Page 18—"A Fac-Simile from the Book of Abraham.		No. 1.	[See p. 28.]
Page 24—"Ditto	Ditto	No. 2.	[See p. 36f.]
Page 29—"Ditto	Ditto	No. 3.	[See p. 41.]

SUBSEQUENT EDITIONS:

First American edition:
1. When: 1878 (Canonized on Sunday, 10 October 1880, in General Conference).
2. Who: Orson Pratt, member of the Council of the Twelve, under the direction of President John Taylor.
3. Why: Popular; therefore, edition needed for American saints.
4. Where: Salt Lake City, Utah.
5. What: Original preface deleted: no longer pertinent. Shorter edition than the 1st edition. The first two entries were combined into one and placed in chronological order. Several passages were added which were omitted in the original edition. (Source: Inspired Version the Bible [JST], published by the Reorganized LDS Church.) Revelation on eternal marriage (D&C 132) added.

James E. Talmage alteration editions:
1. When: 1902 & 1921.
2. Who: James E. Talmage, made a member of the Council of the Twelve in 1911.
3. Why: Make the book more usable (chapters, verses, columns, cross-references, etc.).
4. Where: SLC
5. What: Removed redundant items that were already in the Doctrine and Covenants.

1976 edition:
1. When: 1976
2. Who: First Presidency
3. Why: Two revelations were made canonized scripture.
4. Where: SLC
5. What: Joseph Smith's vision of the celestial kingdom [see D&C 137], and Joseph F. Smith's vision of the redemption of the dead [see D&C 138] added.

1979 edition:
1. When: 1979
2. Who: First Presidency
3. Why: Revelations moved to the D&C.
4. Where: SLC
5. What: Joseph Smith's vision of the celestial kingdom [see D&C 137], and Joseph F. Smith's vision of the redemption of the dead [see D&C 138] removed and placed in the Doctrine and Covenants.

1981 edition:
1. When: 1981
2. Who: First Presidency
3. Why: New publication of the triple combination scriptures.
4. Where: SLC
5. What: New introduction.

{Bibliography for further reference: H. Donl Peterson, *The Pearl of Great Price: A History and Commentary* [SLC: Deseret Book, 1987].}

Marion G. Romney, *Look to God and Live,* comp. George J. Romney (SLC: Deseret Book Company, 1971), pg 116:

By the October 10, 1880, action, the Saints also accepted the contents of the Pearl of Great Price as revelation from God and binding upon them as a people and as a Church.

During the next twenty-two years, under the direction of the presidency of the Church, the content of the book was somewhat revised. Consequently, in October 1902, President Joseph F. Smith, said to the Saints in conference assembled:

> I hold in my hand a copy of the revised edition of the Pearl of Great Price. The Pearl of Great Price as it originally existed, was presented before the General Conference and accepted as one of the standard works of the Church. Since then the book has undergone a revision; that is to say, all the revelations that it formerly contained which were also in the Book of Doctrine and Covenants, have been eliminated from it.... We now present this book in its revised form--the original matter being preserved as it was before, only divided into chapters and verses--for your acceptance as a standard work of the church.
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> It was moved and seconded that the book be accepted as a standard work of the church, and the motion carried unanimously (*Conference Report*, Oct. 6, 1902, pg. 82.)

Historical Background

The Book of Moses

This book is different in its origin and in its content. The Book of Abraham is an inspired, revelatory translation of ancient records that came into the hands of Joseph Smith, the book of Moses is a direct revelation given to him as part of his God-given assignment to prepare a new translation of the Bible. The content of the revelation is similar to that revealed to Moses, which enabled him to write Genesis. In its present form, Genesis no longer contains many of the teachings and doctrines originally placed in it by Moses. But by direct revelation in modern times, the Lord has restored many of the truths lost from these early scriptures written by Moses.

This book is written as though Moses were actually recording what he saw and heard from the Lord. It is not written as though Joseph Smith were speaking.

The Book of Moses contains 8 chapters and covers the same general time period and events found in the first 6 chapters of Genesis in the Bible.

Elder Bruce R. McConkie has written: "The 1st and 7th chapters of Moses are entirely new revelations having no counterpart in Genesis. The other chapters in Moses cover the same events recorded in the first six chapters of Genesis, but the account revealed in latter-days has been so enlarged, contains so much new material, and so radically changes the whole perspective of the Lord's dealings with Adam and the early patriarchs that for all practical purposes it may be considered as entirely new matter. The whole view of the creation of all things; of pre-existence and the purpose of life; of Adam and his fall; of the primeval revelation of the gospel to man; of the terms and conditions with which salvation is offered to the living and the dead; of Enoch, his ministry and his establishment of Zion; and of Noah, his priesthood and ministry—the whole view and perspective relative to all these things is radically changed by the new revelations in the book of Moses. This book which is also contained in the Prophet's Inspired Version of the Bible [now called the Joseph Smith Translation—or JST], is one of the most important documents the Lord has ever revealed." (*Mormon Doctrine,* 2nd ed [SLC: Bookcraft, 1966], pg. 563-564.)

The Book of Abraham

Joseph Smith stated: "Soon after this, some of the Saints at Kirtland purchased the mummies and papyrus, a description of which will appear hereafter, and with W. W. Phelps and Oliver Cowdery as scribes, I commenced the translation of some characters of hieroglyphics, and much to our joy found that one of the rolls contained the writings of Abraham, another the writings of Joseph of Egypt, etc.,—a more full account of which will appear in its place, as I proceed to examine or unfold them." (*History of the Church* ed. B. H. Roberts, 7 vols. [SLC: The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, 1932-1951] 2:236; hereafter cited as *HC.*)

Joseph also said: "The public mind has been excited of late, by reports which have been circulated concerning certain Egyptian mummies and ancient records, which were published by certain gentlemen of Kirtland, last July. It has been said that the purchasers of these antiquities pretend they have the bodies of Abraham, Abimelech, (the king of the Philistines,) Joseph, who was sold into Egypt, etc., etc., for the purpose of attracting the attention of the multitude, and gulling the unwary; which is utterly false.

"Who these ancient inhabitants of Egypt were, I do not at present say. Abraham was buried on his own possession 'in the cave of Machpelah.' … Abimelech lived in the same country, and for aught we know, died there; and the children of Israel carried Joseph's bones from Egypt.…

"The record of Abraham and Joseph, found with the mummies, is beautifully written on papyrus with black, and small part red, ink or paint, in perfect preservation. The characters are such as you find upon the coffins of mummies—hieroglyphics, etc.; with many characters of letters like the present (though probably not quite so square) form of the Hebrew without points.

"The records were obtained from one of the catacombs in Egypt, near the place where once stood the renowned city

of Thebes, by the celebrated French traveler, Antonio Lebolo, in the year 1831. He procured license from Mehemet Ali, then Viceroy of Egypt, under the protection of Chevalier Drovetti, the French Consul, in the year 1828, and employed four hundred and thirty-three men, four months and two days (if I understand correctly)—Egyptian or Turkish soldiers, at from four to six cents per diem, each man. "He entered the catacomb June 7, 1831, and obtained eleven mummies. There were several hundred mummies in the same catacomb; about one hundred embalmed after the first order, and placed in niches, and two or three hundred after the second and third orders, and laid upon the floor or bottom of the grand cavity. The last two orders of embalmed were so decayed, that they could not be removed, and only eleven of the first, found in the niches.

"On his way from Alexandria to Paris, he put in at Trieste, and, after ten days' illness, expired. This was in the year 1832. Previous to his decease, he made a will of the whole, to Mr. Michael H. Chandler, (then in Philadelphia, Pa.,) his nephew, whom he supposed to be in Ireland. Accordingly, the whole were sent to Dublin, and Mr. Chandler's friends ordered them sent to New York, where they were received at the Custom House in the winter or spring of 1833. In April, of the same year, Mr. Chandler paid the duties and took possession of his mummies. Up to this time they had not been taken out of the coffins, nor the coffins opened. On opening the coffins, he discovered that in connection with two of the bodies, was something rolled up with the same kind of linen, saturated with the same bitumen, which, when examined, proved to be two rolls of papyrus, previously mentioned. Two or three other small pieces of papyrus, with astronomical calculations, epitaphs, etc., were found with others of the mummies. When Mr. Chandler discovered that there was something with the mummies, he supposed or hoped it might be some diamonds or valuable metal, and was no little chagrined when he saw his disappointment.

" 'He was immediately told, while yet in the custom house, that there was no man in that city who could translate his roll: but was referred, by the same gentleman, (a stranger,) to Mr. Joseph Smith, Jun., who, continued he, possesses some kind of power of gifts, by which he had previously translated similar characters.'

"I was then unknown to Mr. Chandler, neither did he know that such a book or works as the record of the Nephites, had ben brought before the public. From New York,he took his collection on to Philadelphia, where he obtained the certificate of the learned, and from thence came on to Kirtland, as before related, in July. Thus I have given a brief history of the manner in which the writings of the fathers, Abraham and Joseph, have been preserved, and how I came in possession of the same—a correct translation of which I shall give in its proper place." (*HC* 2:348-351. Paragraphing changed.)

These records, probably buried about 600 b.c., became a part of the Pearl of Great Price. The death of Joseph Smith interrupted the work of translation. Only part of the book of Abraham was completed. We have no record of the translation of the book of Joseph.

Joseph Smith–Matthew

This, like the book of Moses, was part of Joseph Smith's assignment from God to provide a new translation of the Bible. This translation of Matthew 24 provides information regarding 3 periods of apostasy and destruction relative to Jerusalem, including the last days.

Joseph Smith–History

This consists of a history dictated by the Prophet Joseph Smith himself. He tells the events in his life from his birth, through the First Vision, Moroni's visits, the Book of Mormon, and the restoration of the Aaronic Priesthood.

The Articles of Faith

These were taken from a letter written by Joseph Smith to a Mr. Wentworth, editor of the *Chicago Democrat*, about matters of religious interest and debate at the time. It is a summary of *some* of the doctrines of the Church.